Grammar: Talking about the past

💡 **Big idea:** We use the **past simple** for finished actions and actions that happened one after the other, and the **past continuous** for actions **in progress** in the past. When a short action **interrupts** a longer one, we use both tenses together.

🎯 **I will learn:**

- Form the past simple and past continuous
- Choose the correct tense in context
- Use when and while
- Know which verbs are not used in the continuous

📖 Key words

interrupt يقاطع	**in progress** قيد التنفيذ / مستمر	**communication** تواصل	**generation** جيل
expensive غالي	**podcast** بودكاست	**stative** حالة	

Past simple

- Finished actions or situations in the past: I **grew up** in Canada.
- Past habits and repeated events
- Actions one after the other: I **started** to see that language wasn't just about words.

Past continuous

- Actions in progress at a time in the past: At six o'clock I **was walking** to my grandma's house.
- Form: was / were + verb-**ing**
- A longer action interrupted by a shorter one: While I **was chatting** with some local teenagers, I **realised** that my French skills were useful.

Verbs not used in the past continuous

- Stative verbs: **know, like, hate, hear, see**
- ✓ I **saw** French on signs and in stores.
  ✓ I **heard** it on TV.

Chatting to my grandmother

- The writer's grandmother didn't understand why he didn't want to make phone calls
- In the past, phone calls were expensive, so people chatted only in the evenings
- In 2016, communication changed: it became possible to communicate quickly and easily at any cost



We use the past simple for finished actions or situations in the past, past habits, regular past events or past actions that happened one after the other.

I **grew up** in Canada.
I **started** to see that language wasn't just about words.

past continuous

We use the past continuous to describe actions in progress in the past, especially when another action (past simple) interrupts the first one (past continuous).

While I **was chatting** with some local teenagers, I **realised** that my French skills were useful.

Watch or listen

3 2.01 Watch or listen to people talking about actions in progress. Which of these things do they talk about?

A what they were doing last night
B what they were doing when something else happened
C what they were doing when they met their best friend

4 2.01 What did each speaker say? Complete the sentences with the past simple or past continuous form of the verbs in brackets. Watch or listen again and check your answers.

Explore grammar: talking about the past

✏️ Examples

While I ___ (walk) home, it started to rain.

Answer: was walking

Last night at six o'clock I ___ (do) my homework.

Answer: was doing

⭐ Remember

- when + short action (past simple)
- while + long action (past continuous)
- Stative verbs stay in the past simple.

⚠️ Watch out

- ✗ I was knowing the answer. ✓ I knew the answer.
- ✗ While I walked to school, I was seeing my friend. ✓ While I was walking to school, I saw my friend.

🧩 **Activity:** Tell your partner about a time someone called you with good news: what were you doing?

✅ Check yourself

1. Form of past continuous?
2. Which tense for an interrupted action?
3. Past simple of grow?

Answers: (1) was/were + verb-ing ، (2) past continuous ، (3) grew